THE FAMILY CYBERSECURITY HANDBOOK

Safe Together

How to spot and stop phishing, scam calls, deepfakes and AI-powered tricks – for every age, from 8 to 88



PAUSE · CHECK · CALL BACK – the three habits that beat almost every scam

WWW.KRATTUS.COM

Before you begin

Criminals now use artificial intelligence (AI) to write perfect emails, copy the voices of people you love, and even fake live video calls. The good news: **the tricks behind every scam are old, and a few simple habits defeat them** — no matter how clever the technology gets.

This book is written for the whole family. You don't need any technical knowledge. You can read it cover to cover, or jump to the chapter that matters right now. Each chapter ends with a short summary you can share.

Look out for these boxes

KIDS' CORNER
Simple explanations and rules for younger readers. Great to read together.

GRANDPARENT TIP
Extra advice for older adults and those who help them.

THE AI TWIST
How criminals are using AI to make this scam more convincing.

RED FLAGS
Warning signs that something is a scam.

DO THIS
Simple steps that protect you.

REAL-LIFE STORY
Scenarios based on the kinds of scams people really face.

The one idea to remember

Scammers don't hack computers as much as they hack **feelings**.
If a message makes you feel rushed, scared, excited or ashamed – **that is the moment to slow down**.

How families can use this book

- **Read one chapter a week together** — at dinner, on a video call with grandparents, or in the car.
- **Fill in the Family Safety Plan** at the back (page 63). It takes 20 minutes and could save your savings.
- **Choose a family code word** today (Chapter 5). It is the single best defense against AI voice-clone scams.
- **Cut out the wallet card** and stick it by the phone or on the fridge.
- **Make it safe to talk.** Anyone can be fooled — including experts. In this family, nobody gets told off for asking "Is this real?"

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Published by **www.krattus.com**. This handbook gives general safety information, not legal or financial advice. Scams change fast; the habits in this book do not. Phone numbers and websites listed were correct at the time of writing (October 2026) — always look up official contact details yourself.



CHAPTER 1 · PART 1

The New Face of Crime: How AI Changed Scams

Scams used to be easy to spot: bad spelling, strange grammar, an obviously fake prince. Those days are over. Here is what has changed — and what hasn't.

IN THIS CHAPTER

Why scams are suddenly more convincing · The five AI tools criminals use · Why "it looked real" is no longer proof · The good news

Scams have become an industry

Online fraud is no longer the work of a lone trickster. Today it is a global business, with call centres, scripts, managers, and — increasingly — artificial intelligence. Reported losses keep breaking records: in the United States alone, people reported losing about **$12.5 billion to fraud in 2024** (Federal Trade Commission), and the FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center received reports of over **$16 billion** in losses the same year. People over 60 lost the most money; young people were scammed most often. And most scams are never reported at all, because victims feel embarrassed.

That last point matters. **Being scammed is not a sign of stupidity.** Doctors, police officers, bank managers and cybersecurity experts get scammed. The criminals are professionals who practise their tricks all day. This book is about giving you the same advantage: knowing their playbook.

What AI gives the criminals

Artificial intelligence is a type of computer program that can write text, create pictures, copy voices and make videos that look and sound real. It is used for wonderful things — and criminals use the same tools. Here are the five that matter most for your safety:

AI tool	What criminals do with it	What it means for you
Text-writing AI (chatbots)	Write flawless emails and messages in any language, personalised with your name, job, and recent purchases.	Perfect spelling no longer means a message is genuine.
Voice cloning	Copy someone's voice from a few seconds of audio taken from a video, voicemail or social media post.	A phone call that *sounds* like your grandchild may not be them.
Deepfake video	Put a different face on a person in real time during a video call, or create fake videos of celebrities and officials.	Seeing someone's face on a screen is no longer proof of who they are.
Fake images	Create realistic photos of people who don't exist, fake ID cards, fake receipts, fake injury photos.	Profile pictures and "proof" photos can be completely invented.
Chatbots that talk for hours	Run thousands of romance or investment conversations at the same time, never tired, always charming.	An online "friend" who is endlessly patient and attentive may be a machine run by a gang.

THE AI TWIST

Criminals can also feed AI the information you share publicly — your social media posts, your job on LinkedIn, the names of your pets and children — to create a message designed just for you. Security experts call this **spear-phishing**. It used to take hours of research per victim. Now it takes seconds.

The old warning signs that no longer work

DON'T RELY ON THESE ANYMORE

- "It has spelling mistakes" — AI writes perfectly.
- "It knew my name and address" — that data is often leaked or public.
- "It sounded exactly like my son" — voices can be cloned.
- "I saw his face on the video call" — faces can be faked live.
- "The website looked professional" — fake sites take minutes to build.
- "The caller ID showed my bank's number" — numbers can be faked (spoofed).

RELY ON THESE INSTEAD

- **The pressure:** are you being rushed, scared or excited?
- **The request:** money, gift cards, crypto, codes, passwords, remote access?
- **The secrecy:** "don't tell anyone"?
- **The channel:** did *they* contact *you*?
- **The check:** can you verify it by contacting them a different way, using a number *you* already trust?

The good news

AI changes the *costume* a scam wears. It does not change the *skeleton*. Almost every scam — old or new, human or AI — follows the same steps:

1. **Contact:** they reach out to you unexpectedly (email, text, call, social media, ad).
2. **Story:** they tell a story that triggers a strong emotion (fear, love, greed, duty, shame).
3. **Pressure:** they make you act *now*, before you can think or talk to anyone.
4. **Payment or access:** they ask for money, gift cards, crypto, a code, a password, or control of your device.

If you learn to spot that skeleton, it doesn't matter how perfect the email, voice or video is. You will notice the pressure, you will pause, and you will check. That is what the rest of this book teaches.

KIDS' CORNER

Some computers can now pretend to be people. They can copy how someone looks and sounds, like a really good costume. That's why we have a **secret family password** and why you should **always ask a grown-up** before you click, buy, or share anything — even if it looks like it comes from someone you know.

GRANDPARENT TIP

You don't need to understand how AI works to beat it. Just remember: **a real bank, police officer, government office or family member will never be upset if you hang up and call them back** on a number you already know. Only a scammer is angry about that.

Chapter summary: AI makes scams **look** and **sound** real.
So stop judging by looks and sound – judge by **pressure, payment and secrecy**.



CHAPTER 2 · PART 1

Inside the Scammer's Playbook – and the PAUSE Method

Social engineering is the art of tricking people into doing things against their own interests. It works on everyone. Once you can name the tricks, they lose most of their power.

IN THIS CHAPTER

The seven emotional levers · The most common scam stories · The PAUSE method · Why talking to someone is your superpower

Social engineering: hacking people, not computers

It is much easier to trick a person into giving away a password than to break into a computer. That is why almost all cybercrime starts with **social engineering** — manipulating people. The scammer's job is to get you out of your calm, thinking brain and into your fast, emotional brain. When we are frightened, excited or rushed, we stop checking.

The seven levers scammers pull

Lever	What they say	What's really going on
Urgency	"Act within 30 minutes or your account will be closed." "Your grandson is in jail right now."	Time pressure stops you from thinking or asking anyone.
Fear	"Your computer has a virus." "There's a warrant for your arrest." "Your account has been hacked."	Panic switches off careful thinking.
Authority	"This is the police / the tax office / your bank's fraud department / your boss."	We are taught to obey officials. Real officials don't demand gift cards.
Greed & luck	"You've won!" "Guaranteed 30% returns." "Earn €500 a day from home."	If it sounds too good to be true, it is.
Love & sympathy	"Mum, I lost my phone, I need help." "I can't wait to meet you, but I need money for the flight."	We want to help people we care about.
Shame & secrecy	"Don't tell anyone." "If you tell your bank, the investigation fails." "I'll share your photos."	Secrecy keeps you from the people who would spot the scam.
Helpfulness & trust	"Can you just read me the code we sent you, to confirm it's you?"	Being polite and helpful is used against you.

THE THREE BIGGEST RED FLAGS OF ALL

1. **Unusual payment:** gift cards, cryptocurrency, wire transfers, cash couriers, payment apps, "safe accounts", or gold bars. *No real organisation asks for payment in gift cards. Ever.*
2. **Secrecy:** being told not to tell your family, your bank or anyone else.
3. **Urgency:** being told it must happen *right now*.

One of these is a warning. Two together is almost certainly a scam. All three: hang up.

The scam stories you will meet most often

The impostor: someone pretends to be your bank, the police, a tax office, a delivery company, a tech company (Microsoft, Apple, Amazon), or a family member.

The "safe account": a fake bank fraud team says your money is at risk and tells you to move it to a "safe" account — which belongs to the criminals.

The emergency: a loved one is in trouble — an accident, an arrest, a lost phone — and needs money now.

The prize: you've won a lottery, a gift card or a holiday — you just need to pay a small "fee" first.

The tech support: a pop-up or caller says your computer is infected and asks to connect to it remotely.

The investment: a friend, celebrity or online love interest shows you an amazing crypto or trading platform.

The romance: a perfect new partner online who can never meet in person and eventually needs money.

The bargain: concert tickets, puppies, cars or designer goods at prices that seem amazing.

The job: easy money for "liking" videos, reviewing products, or receiving and forwarding money.

The threat: "We have hacked your camera / have your photos — pay or we share them."

Your shield: the PAUSE method

You don't need to memorise every scam. You need one habit you can use in *any* situation — an email, a text, a call, a video, a knock at the door. We call it **PAUSE**:

P	A	U	S	E
Pause	**Ask**	**Use another way**	**Share**	**Exit**
Stop. Take a breath. Real problems can wait 10 minutes.	Is this asking for money, a code, a password, a click, or secrecy?	Contact the person or company yourself, using a number or app *you* already trust.	Tell someone you trust before you act. Scams hate a second opinion.	Hang up, close, delete, block, report. You never owe a stranger a reply.

P – Pause

Urgency is the scammer's most important weapon. So take it away. Say out loud: "*I'll call you back.*" Close the email. Put the phone down. Make a cup of tea. A genuine bank, police officer or family member will still be there in ten minutes. A scam usually won't survive the wait.

A – Ask yourself the key questions

- ☐ Did *they* contact *me*, out of the blue?
- ☐ Are they asking me to pay, move money, or buy gift cards or crypto?
- ☐ Are they asking for a password, PIN, or a code sent to my phone?
- ☐ Are they asking me to click a link, open an attachment, scan a QR code, or install an app?
- ☐ Am I being told to keep it secret or to lie to my bank?
- ☐ Am I feeling scared, rushed, excited, or embarrassed?

If you ticked **any** box, move straight to step U.

U – Use another way to check

This is the most powerful habit in the whole book. **Never verify a message using the contact details the message gives you.** Instead:

- Bank? Call the number on the back of your card, or open your banking app yourself.
- Family member? Hang up and call them on the number saved in your phone — or ask the family code word.
- Company or delivery? Go to their official website or app by typing it yourself, not by clicking.

- Boss or colleague? Check in person, on a known number, or on your company's usual chat.

GRANDPARENT TIP

After a suspicious call on a landline, **wait five minutes or use a different phone** before calling your bank. Some criminals stay on the line after you "hang up", so when you dial they are still there pretending to be the bank.

S – Share it with someone

Scammers work hard to isolate you, because a second person spots the scam instantly. Make a family rule: **before any unusual payment, we always talk to one other person.** No exceptions, no embarrassment.

E – Exit

It's okay to be rude to a scammer. You can hang up mid-sentence. You can delete without replying. You can block. Then report it (see page 69) so others are protected too.

KIDS' CORNER – THE STOP-THINK-ASK RULE

STOP — don't click, don't reply. **THINK** — is someone asking for something, or offering something that's too good to be true? **ASK** — show a grown-up you trust. You will never be in trouble for asking!

Chapter summary: Every scam pulls an emotional lever. Your answer is always the same:
Pause, Ask, Use another way, Share, Exit.



CHAPTER 3 · PART 2

Phishing Emails

"Phishing" is when criminals send a message pretending to be someone you trust, hoping you'll bite: click a link, open a file, type a password, or send money. Email is where it all started — and it's still where most attacks begin.

IN THIS CHAPTER

Anatomy of a phishing email · How to check a link without clicking · Dangerous attachments · Business email scams · What to do if you clicked

Anatomy of a phishing email

Here is a typical modern phishing email. Notice that the spelling is perfect — because AI wrote it. The numbers show where the clues are.

From: Customer Security <security@paypa1-account-review.com> (1)
To: you
Subject: Action required: unusual sign-in detected — account limited (2)

Dear Valued Customer, (3)

We detected a sign-in to your account from a new device in **Lagos, Nigeria** on 14 October at 03:12. To protect you, we have temporarily limited your account.

If this was not you, please verify your identity **within 24 hours** or your account will be permanently suspended and any remaining balance frozen. (4)

Verify my account (5) (link goes to: http://secure-verify-login.co/pp/auth)

Please also review the attached security report. (6) 📎 *Security_Report.pdf.html*

Thank you for being a valued member.
The Security Team

1. **The sender's address is wrong.** The display name says "Customer Security", but the actual address is a look-alike domain: *paypa1* with the number 1 instead of the letter L. Always look at the real address, not just the name.
2. **Alarming subject line** designed to make you panic.
3. **Generic greeting** — though be careful: AI phishing often *does* use your real name now.
4. **A deadline and a threat.** Urgency + fear = classic manipulation.
5. **The button goes somewhere else.** The link doesn't lead to the real company's website.
6. **A dangerous attachment.** A file ending in *.html* pretending to be a PDF can open a fake login page.

How to check a link without clicking it

- **On a computer:** rest your mouse pointer over the link (don't click). The real web address appears at the bottom corner of the screen or in a small pop-up.
- **On a phone or tablet:** press and hold the link (don't tap) until a preview shows the address. Then close the preview.
- **Read the address from right to left, starting at the first single slash "/".** The part just before it is the real owner. In *www.amazon.com.account-check.net/login*, the real owner is

account-check.net — not Amazon.

Web address	Real or fake?	Why
https://www.paypal.com/signin	Real	The domain is paypal.com.
https://paypal.com.security-check.io/signin	Fake	The real domain is security-check.io.
https://www.paypaI.com (capital i)	Fake	Look-alike letters.
https://bit.ly/3xYz9 or other short links	Unknown	Short links hide the destination. Don't trust them in unexpected messages.
https://mybank-secure-login.com	Fake	Extra words like "secure", "login", "verify" in a domain are a common trick.

THE SAFEST HABIT

Don't use links in emails to log in to anything important. Instead, open the company's app, or type their address yourself, or use a bookmark you saved. If there really is a problem with your account, you'll see it there. This one habit defeats almost every phishing email — however perfect it looks.

Also note: the padlock symbol (🔒) and "https" only mean the connection is encrypted. **Scam sites have padlocks too.** A padlock does not mean a site is honest.

Dangerous attachments

Attachments can install malicious software ("malware") or open fake login pages. Be very careful with unexpected:

- Invoices, receipts, delivery notes, "voicemail" messages, or "scanned documents" you weren't expecting.
- Files ending in **.zip, .exe, .scr, .js, .iso, .img, .html, .htm, .svg**, or Office documents that ask you to "Enable Content" or "Enable Macros". Never enable macros on a document you received unexpectedly.
- Files with double endings, like *Invoice.pdf.exe* or *Report.pdf.html*.
- Links to "shared documents" on file-sharing services that then ask you to log in with your email password.

Common phishing email stories

"**Your account is locked**" — from banks, PayPal, Netflix, Apple, Microsoft or your email provider.

"**Your parcel couldn't be delivered**" — pay a small fee to reschedule.

"**Tax refund available**" — from a fake tax authority.

"**Invoice / payment confirmation**" — for something you never ordered, with a phone number to "cancel". Calling it connects you to scammers. This is called *callback phishing*.

"**Your subscription will renew for €399**" — antivirus or software you don't have.

"**Your mailbox is full**" — log in to get more storage.

"**Someone shared a document with you**" — leads to a fake login page.

"**You have a new voicemail / fax**" — attachment or link.

At work: Business Email Compromise

One of the most costly scams in the world targets businesses, schools, charities and clubs. A criminal pretends to be the boss, a supplier, or a lawyer and asks for an urgent payment — or says a supplier's **bank details have changed**. Sometimes they actually hack a real email account and send it from there.

REAL-LIFE STORY

In early 2024, an employee at a multinational engineering firm's Hong Kong office joined a video call with what appeared to be the company's chief financial officer and several colleagues. Every one of them was an AI deepfake. Convinced, the employee made a series of transfers totalling around **US$25 million** to the criminals. The original contact? A phishing email.

DO THIS AT WORK

- **Any change of bank details is verified by phone** using a number you already had — never the one in the email.
- Urgent, secret payment requests from "the boss" are checked in person or on a known number. Good bosses will thank you.
- Report suspicious emails to your IT team using the "Report phishing" button, even if you clicked. Speed matters more than pride.

The AI twist on email

THE AI TWIST

- **Perfect language** in any language — including small languages that used to be safe because scammers couldn't write them well.
- **Personalisation at scale:** your name, employer, recent trip, or a real colleague's name scraped from the internet.
- **Reply chains:** AI can continue a believable conversation if you respond — so don't reply to "check".
- **Fake "AI assistant" emails:** messages pretending to come from AI services asking you to renew or verify your account.

What to do if you clicked

Don't panic — and don't hide it. Fast action makes a huge difference.

1. **If you only clicked and didn't type anything:** close the page. Run your device's security scan and make sure your system is up to date. The risk is usually low.
2. **If you typed a password:** change that password immediately (by going to the real site yourself), and anywhere else you use the same password. Turn on 2-step verification (Chapter 9).
3. **If you typed card or bank details:** call your bank using the number on your card *now*, and block the card.
4. **If you opened an attachment or installed something:** disconnect from the internet and get help from someone trustworthy or a reputable repair service. See Chapter 13.
5. **At work:** tell your IT team immediately.

KIDS' CORNER

Some emails are like a fishing hook hidden inside a worm. They might say you've won a game prize, free coins, or that your account will be deleted. **Never click links in emails or type your password after clicking a link.** Show a grown-up instead. Real game companies never ask for your password.

Chapter summary: Don't judge an email by how it looks. Judge it by **what it wants**.
Never log in through an email link – **go to the app or website yourself**.



CHAPTER 4 · PART 2

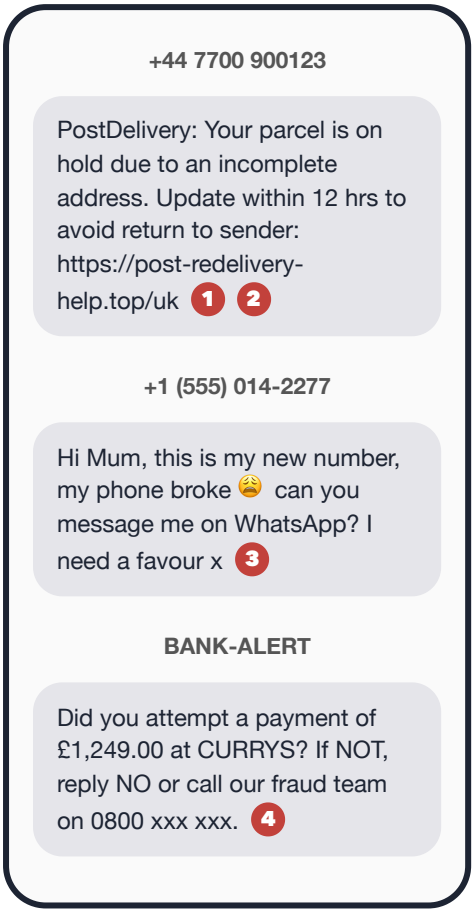
Text Messages, Chat Apps & QR Codes

Scam texts ("smishing") and chat-app messages feel personal and urgent, and phones make it harder to see where links really go. They're now one of the most common ways criminals reach people.

IN THIS CHAPTER

The parcel, toll and bank texts · The "Hi Mum" scam · Wrong-number messages · Account takeover via verification codes · QR code traps

Spot the scam text



1. **An odd number or a strange link** ending in .top, .xyz, .info, .click or similar — not the real company's site.
2. **A small fee or "update" and a deadline.** Delivery companies don't text you random links to pay customs or redelivery fees.
3. **"Hi Mum / Hi Dad" from a new number.** One of the most successful scams in the world. Soon they'll need money for a bill "because my banking app doesn't work on the new phone".
4. **Fake fraud alert.** If you reply or call, a "fraud team" will talk you into moving money to a "safe account" or reading out codes. Instead, call the number on the back of your card.

Scam texts can even appear in the same thread as genuine messages from your bank, because sender names can be faked.

The most common text and chat scams

Scam	How it works
Parcel / postal	A fake courier or post office says a delivery failed and asks for a small fee. The real goal is your card details.
Road toll / parking fine	"Unpaid toll — pay today to avoid penalty." Toll and parking authorities don't usually text payment links out of the blue.
"Hi Mum / Hi Dad"	A "child" with a new number needs urgent money. With AI, they may even send a voice note that sounds like your child.
Fake bank alert	Leads to a call with a fake fraud team who tricks you into moving money or sharing codes.

"Wrong number"	"Hi Linda, are we still on for golf?" If you reply politely, a friendly chat begins… that weeks later turns into a crypto investment or romance scam (see Chapter 8).
Verification code theft	"I sent you a 6-digit code by mistake, can you forward it to me?" That code lets them take over your WhatsApp, email or bank account.
Job offers	"Earn €300 a day from home, just reply!" Leads to task scams where you pay to "unlock" earnings.
Prize / survey	"Congratulations, you've been selected for a reward." You pay for "shipping" or give card details.

The golden rule of codes: **A verification code is like the key to your front door.**
Never share it with anyone – not your bank, not "support", not a friend who asks.

Protect your WhatsApp, Signal, Telegram and other chat apps

- Turn on **two-step verification / registration lock / PIN** in the app's privacy or account settings. This stops someone taking over your account even if they get a code.
- If a friend asks for a code or money in a chat, **call them** on their normal number. Their account may have been hijacked.
- Be careful when added to unknown **groups** — investment "clubs" and "trading signal" groups are often scams full of fake members cheering each other on.
- Check who can add you to groups and who can see your profile photo and "last seen" in privacy settings.

QR code traps ("quishing")

QR codes are just links in picture form — so they can lead to fake websites, too. Criminals stick fake QR stickers on parking meters, EV chargers, restaurant tables and posters, and put them in emails and letters to bypass spam filters.

DO

- Check whether a QR sticker has been placed over the original.
- Read the web address your camera shows before opening it.
- For payments, use the official app you downloaded from the app store, or pay at the machine.

DON'T

- Scan QR codes in unexpected emails or letters asking you to "verify" or "pay".
- Enter card details or passwords on a page you reached via a random QR code.
- Install apps from a QR code; use your official app store.

What to do with scam texts

1. **Don't reply** — not even "STOP". Replying confirms your number is active.
2. **Don't click** the link, even "just to see".
3. **Report it:** in many countries, including the UK and USA, you can forward scam texts to **7726** (spells "SPAM" on the keypad) for free. Use your phone's "Report junk" option too.
4. **Block and delete** the sender.
5. **If you clicked and entered details**, call your bank immediately using the number on your card.

KIDS' CORNER

If someone messages you that you don't know — even if they seem friendly or say they know your friend — **don't reply, and tell a grown-up**. And remember: those little codes your phone or game sends you are like secret keys. **Never give a code to anyone**, even a friend.

GRANDPARENT TIP

If you get a "Hi Mum" or "Hi Grandad" message from a new number, reply nothing. Call your family member on their **old, saved number**. If they really have a new phone, they'll be happy you checked — and it only takes a minute.

Chapter summary: Never click links in unexpected texts. **Never share a code.** When "family" writes from a new number, **call the old one**.



CHAPTER 5 · PART 2

Phone Scams & AI Voice Clones

A familiar voice, a frightened tone, a demand for money. With just a few seconds of audio, AI can now copy anyone's voice. The phone is where some of the biggest losses happen — and where one simple family habit can stop them.

IN THIS CHAPTER

Caller ID spoofing · Voice-clone emergencies · Fake bank, police and tech-support calls · The family code word · Robocalls and voicemail tips

Caller ID can lie

Criminals can make any number appear on your screen — your bank's real number, the police, even a family member's name if it's saved in your phone. This is called **spoofing**. **A familiar number on the screen proves nothing.**

The voice-clone emergency

REAL-LIFE STORY

Margaret, 74, answers the phone late in the evening. It's her grandson, Tom — his voice, his way of saying "Gran". He's crying. He's been in a car accident, he's been arrested, and he needs money for bail. "Please don't tell Mum and Dad, I'm so ashamed." Then a "lawyer" comes on the line, very calm and professional, and explains that €4,000 in cash will be collected by a courier within the hour.

Margaret's daughter had set up a family code word the month before. Margaret asks: "What's our word, Tom?" The line goes dead. Tom was at home, safe, watching football. The scammers had cloned his voice from videos he had posted online.

THE AI TWIST

Voice-cloning tools need only a short clip — from a social media video, a voicemail greeting, or even a few seconds of a phone call where you said "Hello? Who is this?". The clone can then say anything, in real time, with emotion: crying, panic, whispering. Scammers often add background noise (traffic, a police station) and keep the call short and chaotic so you don't notice small glitches.

The family code word – your strongest defense

Choose a secret word or phrase that everyone in the family knows, that is **never written online or said on social media**, and that a stranger couldn't guess. If anyone calls claiming to be family and asking for money or help, ask for the code word.

GOOD CODE WORDS

- Random and silly: "purple pancake", "Uncle Bob's canoe"
- A phrase only your family would remember but no one posts about
- Easy for children and grandparents to recall under stress

BAD CODE WORDS

- Pet names, street names, birthdays, school names
- Anything that appears on social media
- Something the caller could guess from your reaction

How to use it: never say the word first — ask the caller for it. If they "forgot", hang up and call the person directly on their saved number. Also agree a **back-up question** (e.g. "What did we eat on your last birthday?") in case of genuine stress.

Write your code word down only in your Family Safety Plan (page 63), kept somewhere private at home.

The most common phone scams

The caller says...	What they want	The truth
"**Your bank's fraud team**"	Move money to a "safe account", read out codes, give card PIN, hand your card to a courier.	Banks never ask you to move money to keep it safe, never ask for your PIN or full password, and never send couriers for cards.
"**Police / investigator**"	Help with a "secret investigation" by withdrawing cash, buying gold, or transferring money.	Police never ask you to handle money for an investigation or keep it secret from your bank.
"**Tax office / government**"	Immediate payment of a fine or back-tax, often by gift card or crypto, with threats of arrest.	Government agencies write to you first and never demand gift cards or crypto.
"**Tech support**" (Microsoft, Apple, your internet provider)	Remote access to your computer to "fix a virus", then access to online banking or a "refund" trick.	Tech companies don't call you unexpectedly about viruses.
"**Family member in trouble**"	Bail, hospital fees, a lawyer, a fine — cash, transfer, or gift cards.	Ask for the code word. Call them back on their real number.
"**You've won / you're owed a refund**"	A "processing fee" or your bank details to send the money.	You can't win a lottery you never entered, and real refunds don't need fees.

"Your energy / phone / internet will be cut off"	Immediate payment.	Check by calling the company on the number on your bill.

PHRASES THAT MEAN "SCAM" – EVERY TIME

- "Move your money to a safe account."
- "Don't tell the bank staff why you are withdrawing the money."
- "Buy gift cards and read me the numbers on the back."
- "A courier will come to collect your card / cash / gold."
- "Install this app so I can help you" (remote access apps like AnyDesk or TeamViewer).
- "Read me the code we just sent you."
- "Stay on the line — don't hang up or call anyone else."

Phone safety habits

- **Let unknown numbers go to voicemail.** Real callers leave a message.
- **Use a voicemail greeting without your voice** (the phone's default robotic greeting) to give cloners less audio.
- **Hang up and call back** on an official number you look up yourself. Use a different phone, or wait five minutes, if using a landline.
- **Don't say much to unknown callers.** Avoid saying "yes" to open questions like "Can you hear me?" — say "Who is calling?" instead.
- **Turn on spam call filtering** on your phone (e.g. "Silence Unknown Callers" on iPhone, "Caller ID & spam protection" on Android) and ask your phone provider about free call-blocking services.
- **Never allow remote access** to your computer for anyone who called *you*.

GRANDPARENT TIP

Keep a note by your phone: "**I never give codes, PINs or money over the phone. I'll call you back.**" Read it out if you feel pressured, then hang up. It is not rude — it's smart. Your bank will be proud of you.

KIDS' CORNER

If someone calls and says Mum or Dad is hurt or in trouble, or that you must do something right now — **hang up and call your parent or another trusted adult**. Ask callers for the family secret word. Real family will know it.

Chapter summary: Voices and numbers can be faked. **Ask for the code word. Hang up and call back.**
No real bank or police officer will ever ask you to move money or keep secrets.



CHAPTER 6 · PART 2

Deepfake Videos & Fake Faces

A celebrity promoting a "secret" investment. A politician saying something shocking. Your boss on a video call asking for a transfer. AI can now make video that is almost impossible to tell apart from reality.

IN THIS CHAPTER

What deepfakes are · Celebrity investment ads · Live deepfake video calls · How to test a video call · Fake photos, documents and AI "girlfriends"

What is a deepfake?

A **deepfake** is a video, image or audio clip created or changed with AI so that a person appears to say or do something they never did. Some are made for fun. Criminals use them to:

- **Sell fake investments** — fake videos of famous business leaders, TV presenters or even prime ministers recommending a crypto or trading platform. These appear as ads on social media and video sites.
- **Impersonate bosses and colleagues** on video calls to approve payments.
- **Impersonate loved ones** in short video messages.
- **Romance scams** — a "partner" who can now do video calls with a stolen or invented face.
- **Blackmail ("sextortion")** — creating fake intimate images from normal photos (see Chapter 7).
- **Spread false information** to make people angry, scared, or to influence votes.

Spotting a deepfake – and why you shouldn't rely on it

Older or cheaper deepfakes still show clues. Look for:

• Mouth movements that don't quite match the words

• Strange blinking, or a fixed, glassy stare

• Blurring or flickering around the hairline, ears, glasses or jewellery

• Skin that looks too smooth, or lighting that doesn't match the background

• Hands and fingers that look odd or are kept out of view

• A flat, emotionless voice — or odd pauses and breathing

• Low video quality "because of bad connection"

• The person avoids turning their head sideways

THE AI TWIST

The newest deepfakes fix most of these flaws. That's why the most important question is not "Does it look real?" but "**What is this video asking me to do?**" A real celebrity does not need your savings. A real CEO does not ask for secret transfers on a video call. Use PAUSE.

Test a suspicious video call

If something feels wrong on a video call — especially if money, passwords or secrecy are involved — try these:

1. **Ask them to turn their head fully to the side**, or to wave a hand slowly in front of their face. Many live deepfakes glitch.
2. **Ask a personal question** only the real person could answer — something not online.
3. **Ask for the family or team code word.**
4. **End the call and call them back** on a number you already have. This is the test that always works.

Fake celebrity investment ads

RED FLAGS

- A famous person "reveals the secret" to getting rich, often on what looks like a news website.
- "Banks hate this", "the government wants to ban this", "limited spots".
- You're asked to register and a "financial advisor" calls you soon after.
- Small first investment (around €250) that shows amazing "profits" on a dashboard.

Celebrities do not promote secret investment platforms. If you see one, report the ad on the platform and never register your details.

Fake photos and documents

AI can generate realistic photos of people who don't exist, along with fake passports, ID cards, bank statements, medical bills, and screenshots of payments. So:

- A photo of an ID card is **not** proof of identity.
- A screenshot of a payment is **not** proof you were paid — check your own bank account.
- A beautiful profile photo can be invented. A reverse image search (Google Lens, TinEye, Bing Visual Search) may find stolen photos, but AI-generated ones won't show up — so a "clean" result doesn't prove anything.

Shocking news videos

Before you share or react to a video that makes you angry or afraid, check whether trusted news organisations are reporting the same story. Fake videos are designed to spread through outrage. A good rule: **the more emotional a video makes you, the more carefully you should check it.**

KIDS' CORNER

Computers can make videos of people saying things they never said — even famous YouTubers or game streamers. If a video says you can get free skins, coins or money, **it's a trick**. Never make fake videos or pictures of friends or classmates, either. It can really hurt people, and in many places it's against the law.

Chapter summary: **Seeing is no longer believing.**
If a video asks for money, secrecy or a click – **end the call and check another way**.



CHAPTER 7 · PART 2

Social Media, Romance Scams & Sextortion

Social media connects us with friends — and gives criminals a window into our lives. It's where they gather information, build fake relationships, and set long, patient traps.

IN THIS CHAPTER

Oversharing and what it gives away · Hacked friends and fake profiles · Romance scams · "Pig butchering" · Sextortion – what to do · Privacy settings

What your posts tell a scammer

Every public post is information criminals — and their AI tools — can use. A few innocent posts can reveal your full name, birthday, pet's name (a common password!), children's school, home area, holiday dates (house empty!), employer, and enough voice and video to clone you.

SHARE SMARTER

- Set accounts to **private / friends only**.
- Post holiday photos **after** you're home.
- Keep children's full names, schools and faces off public posts.
- Review your old public posts and videos once a year.

THINK TWICE BEFORE

- "What's your street + first pet = your rock-star name" quizzes — they harvest security answers.
- Posting boarding passes, tickets, ID cards, keys or car number plates.
- Accepting friend requests from strangers or "second accounts" of people you're already friends with.

Hacked friends and copied profiles

A message from a friend's real account can still be a scam if their account was hacked. Common examples: "Is this you in this video? 😱 [link]", "Can you vote for my niece in this competition?" (leads to a code being sent to you), "I'm stuck abroad, can you lend me money?", or "I made so much money with this crypto trader!". Criminals also **clone** profiles: copying your friend's photos into a new account and re-adding all their friends.

The fix is always the same: contact your friend in a different way — call or text their known number — before clicking or sending anything.

Romance scams

Romance scammers build a relationship over weeks or months, through dating apps, social media, games or even "wrong number" texts. They are often criminal gangs working from scripts — and now AI chatbots write many of the messages and deepfakes power the video calls.

RED FLAGS OF A ROMANCE SCAM

- They fall in love very quickly and use intense language ("soulmate", "destiny").
- They are unusually attractive and successful: a doctor abroad, an engineer on an oil rig, a soldier on a mission, a successful investor.
- They want to move quickly from the dating app to WhatsApp, Telegram or another private chat.
- They can never meet in person. Plans always fall through at the last minute.
- Video calls are rare, short, blurry or "broken" — or they look a bit too perfect.
- Eventually there's a crisis: medical bills, a stuck inheritance, customs fees, a plane ticket — or an "amazing investment opportunity" they want to share with you.
- They ask you to keep the relationship secret, or to not listen to family who "don't understand".

If someone you have never met in person asks you for money, it is a scam – no matter how real the love feels.

If you're worried about a friend or relative in a possible romance scam, be gentle. They may feel real love and deep shame. Arguing can push them closer to the scammer. Listen, ask questions ("Have you ever met in person? Have you video-called without problems?"), and suggest a reverse image search together.

"Pig butchering": the long investment con

This cruelly named scam "fattens" victims with friendship or romance before the "slaughter". It usually starts with a random message or a "wrong number" text. Over weeks of friendly chat, the new friend mentions they make money trading crypto, gold or currencies, and offers to teach you. You're directed to a professional-looking app or website that shows your investment growing fast. You may even be allowed to withdraw a small amount to build trust. Then you invest more — sometimes your life savings or borrowed money. When you try to withdraw, there are "taxes" or "fees" to pay first. The money is gone. Many of these operations are run from scam compounds where trafficked workers are forced to message victims.

Sextortion: a guide for teens, parents and adults

Sextortion is blackmail: someone threatens to share intimate images of you unless you pay or send more. It targets teenage boys especially, often by a fake profile of an attractive girl who sends images first and then asks for some in return. Within minutes, the threats begin. Criminals can also create fake nude images from ordinary photos using AI — so **you don't need to have**

sent anything to be targeted. There is also a common email version claiming "I hacked your webcam" — those emails are almost always bluffs.

IF IT HAPPENS: WHAT TO DO

1. **You are not in trouble, and you are not alone.** This is a crime committed against you.
2. **Stop replying.** Don't negotiate.
3. **Don't pay.** Paying almost never ends it — they usually ask for more.
4. **Save evidence:** screenshots of the profile, messages, usernames and payment requests. Don't delete your account yet.
5. **Block and report** the account on the platform.
6. **Tell a trusted adult** and report to the police.
7. **Get images removed:** if you're under 18, use **Take It Down** (takeitdown.ncmec.org). Adults can use **StopNCII.org**. Both create a digital fingerprint so participating platforms can block the images — without anyone having to see them.

FOR PARENTS & GRANDPARENTS

Tell your children and grandchildren now, before anything happens: "**If anyone ever threatens you online, come to me. I will help you and I will not be angry.**" Criminals rely on kids being too ashamed to tell an adult. Tragically, some young victims have harmed themselves out of panic. One calm conversation can save a life.

Privacy settings checklist

- [ ] Make profiles private; limit who can message you, tag you and find you by phone number or email.
- [ ] Hide your friends list and your birth year.
- [ ] Turn off location sharing on posts and photos.
- [ ] Turn on 2-step verification for every social account (Chapter 9).
- [ ] Review which apps and games are connected to your account and remove ones you don't use.
- [ ] Use the platform's "Security check-up" or "Privacy check-up" tool once a year.

KIDS' CORNER

People online aren't always who they say they are. A "kid your age" might be an adult. **Never send photos of yourself to people you've only met online, never share where you live or go to school, and never agree to meet someone from the internet** without a parent. If something online makes you feel weird, scared or uncomfortable — tell a grown-up. That's being brave, not being a snitch.

Chapter summary: Share less, verify friends, and remember: **online love that asks for money is a scam**. If you're threatened, **don't pay – tell someone**.



CHAPTER 8 · PART 2

Money Traps: Shopping, Investment, Crypto & Job Scams

Fake shops, fake bargains, fake investments, fake jobs. AI can build a convincing online store in minutes and a whole fake investment platform in a day. Here's how to keep your money where it belongs.

IN THIS CHAPTER

Fake shops and marketplace tricks · Investment and crypto scams · Recovery scams · Job and "task" scams · Money mules · Charity and ticket scams

Fake online shops

RED FLAGS

- Prices far below everywhere else — especially on electronics, designer goods, trainers, and popular toys.
- A website found through a social media ad, with a strange or very new web address.
- No real contact details, address or phone number; vague returns policy.
- Reviews that are all perfect, all similar, or all posted on the same few days.
- Payment only by bank transfer, crypto or payment apps — not by card.
- "Closing down sale — everything 80% off!"

DO THIS

- **Pay by credit card** (or a debit card / reputable payment service with buyer protection). Card payments can often be disputed if goods never arrive. Bank transfers usually can't.
- Search the shop's name plus the words "scam" or "reviews" before buying.
- Type well-known shop addresses yourself instead of clicking ads.
- Consider a virtual card or a separate low-limit card for online shopping.

Marketplace tricks (buying and selling)

Trick	How to stay safe
Seller wants payment by bank transfer or "Friends & Family"	Use the platform's own protected checkout, or pay in person on collection.
Buyer sends a link to "receive payment" or "confirm delivery"	You never need to enter card details to *receive* money. This link steals your card.
Buyer "overpays" and asks for the difference back	The original payment will bounce. Never refund overpayments.
Fake payment screenshot or email	Only trust money you can see in your own bank account, logged in yourself.
Rental property or pet "deposit" before viewing	Never pay before seeing the property or animal in person (or via a verified agent).

Concert / sports tickets from strangers	Buy only from official sellers or official resale platforms.

Investment and crypto scams

These cause some of the largest losses of all, and they are increasingly powered by AI: deepfake celebrity endorsements, AI chatbots in "trading groups", and fake platforms that look exactly like real ones.

RED FLAGS

- **Guaranteed** high returns with "no risk". Real investments always carry risk.
- Pressure to invest quickly — "the opportunity closes tonight".
- You were approached by someone, rather than you seeking out a regulated adviser.
- You're asked to buy crypto and send it to a platform or "wallet address".
- You're asked to install a remote-access app "so we can help you set up your account".
- You must pay "taxes", "fees" or a "deposit" before you can withdraw.
- An "AI trading bot" or "quantum AI" that can't lose.

BEFORE YOU INVEST A SINGLE EURO, POUND OR DOLLAR

- Check that the firm is **registered with your country's financial regulator** (e.g. the SEC/FINRA in the US, the FCA in the UK, your national authority in the EU) and check their warning lists of known scam firms.
- Contact the firm using details from the regulator's register — not from the ad or chat.
- Talk it over with someone you trust who has nothing to gain.
- Never invest money you can't afford to lose — and never borrow to invest on a stranger's advice.

This handbook can't give personal investment advice. If in doubt, speak with a licensed, regulated financial adviser you have found yourself.

Recovery scams: the second hit

After someone loses money, criminals often come back pretending to be lawyers, "crypto recovery experts", government agencies or even the police, offering to get the money back — for an upfront fee. **Anyone who contacts you offering to recover lost money for a fee is almost certainly a scammer**, often the same gang. Go through the police and your bank only.

Job and "task" scams

- **Task scams:** you're paid small amounts to "like" videos, rate products or "optimise apps". Then you must deposit your own money to unlock bigger tasks or withdraw your earnings. The money disappears.
- **Fake job offers:** a quick text or chat interview (often by AI), then requests for your ID, bank details, or a fee for training or equipment.
- **Reshipping:** you receive parcels at home and forward them — usually goods bought with stolen cards.

Real employers don't hire by WhatsApp in five minutes, and they don't ask *you* to pay *them*.

Money mules: a warning for young people

Criminals recruit students and young people on social media: "Earn easy money — just let us use your bank account for a few days." Moving money for someone else is called being a **money mule**, and it is **money laundering** — a serious crime. Mules can have their bank accounts closed, struggle to get loans or phones for years, and face prosecution. Never let anyone use your bank account, card, or identity.

Other money traps

Fake charities spring up after every disaster. Give through charities you know, via their official websites.

Subscription traps: "free trial — just pay shipping" that becomes a monthly charge. Read the small print.

Holiday rentals: fake listings on copied photos. Book through reputable platforms and never pay outside them.

Fake loans: "guaranteed approval" if you pay an upfront fee first. Legitimate lenders don't do that.

Lottery and inheritance: you didn't enter, you don't have a rich unknown relative.

Fake ticket refunds and travel compensation services asking for card details.

KIDS' CORNER

"Free Robux", "free V-Bucks", "free skins" and "free gift cards" sites are tricks to steal your account or your parents' money. **Nothing free needs your password.** Always ask before buying anything in a game, and only buy from inside the official game or store.

Chapter summary: **Too good to be true = not true.** Pay by card, buy from real shops,
check regulators before investing, and **never pay to get paid**.



CHAPTER 9 · PART 3

Passwords, Passkeys & 2-Step Verification

Even the best scam-spotter will one day slip up. Strong account security means that one mistake doesn't turn into a disaster. This chapter is the "seatbelt" of your digital life.

IN THIS CHAPTER

Why reused passwords are dangerous · Passphrases · Password managers · 2-step verification · Passkeys · Protecting your email first

Why one leaked password can unlock your life

Companies get hacked, and billions of email addresses and passwords have been leaked online. Criminals use automated tools to try those leaked combinations on thousands of other websites. This is called **credential stuffing**. If you use the same password for a shopping site and your email, a leak at the shop means criminals can get into your email — and from there, reset the passwords of everything else.

> Your **email account** is the master key to your digital life.
> Protect it with a unique password and 2-step verification **first**.

The three rules of passwords

1. **Long:** at least 12–16 characters. Length matters more than complexity.
2. **Unique:** a different password for every important account.
3. **Secret:** never shared, never typed into a site you reached from a link in a message.

Use passphrases

A **passphrase** is several random words strung together. It's long, strong, and easy to remember:

Password	Strength	Why
Fluffy2015!	Weak	Pet name + year + symbol is the first thing attackers try.
P@ssw0rd123	Very weak	Swapping letters for symbols doesn't fool computers.
Tr0ub4dor&3	Okay-ish	Hard to remember, shorter than you'd think.
violin-cactus-harbor-pickle	Strong	Four random words: long and memorable.

Avoid names, birthdays, addresses, sports teams, and anything on your social media.

Password managers: the easiest way to do it right

Nobody can remember 100 different strong passwords. A **password manager** is a secure app that creates, stores and fills in passwords for you. You only remember **one** strong passphrase to open it.

- **Built-in options:** Apple Passwords (iPhone, iPad, Mac), Google Password Manager (Android, Chrome), and Microsoft's built-in options.
- **Dedicated apps:** well-known, independently audited managers such as Bitwarden, 1Password, Proton Pass or Dashlane. Many offer family plans.
- **Bonus protection:** a password manager won't fill in your password on a fake look-alike website — a great extra warning sign.

GRANDPARENT TIP

If an app feels like too much, a **paper password book kept safely at home** (not in your wallet, not stuck to the computer) is far better than using the same password everywhere. Write hints rather than full passwords if you prefer. The danger online is criminals far away — not a burglar reading your notebook.

2-step verification: your second lock

2-step verification (2SV), also called two-factor (2FA) or multi-factor authentication (MFA), means that logging in needs your password *plus* something else — usually your phone. Even if a criminal steals your password, they can't get in without that second step. It blocks the vast majority of account-takeover attacks.

Type	Protection	Notes
Passkey or security key	Best	Can't be phished: it only works on the genuine website.
Authenticator app (Google Authenticator, Microsoft Authenticator, etc.)	Very good	Generates a code on your phone. Still: never read the code to anyone.
App prompt ("Is this you trying to sign in?")	Good	Only tap "Yes" if *you* are signing in right now. Repeated prompts = someone has your password.
Code by text (SMS)	Okay	Much better than nothing. Ask your phone company for a PIN to protect against SIM-swap fraud.

THE "APPROVE IT" TRICK

If your phone suddenly asks "Approve sign-in?" and you're not signing in, **tap No / Deny** — and change your password, because someone has it. Criminals sometimes send dozens of prompts at night, hoping you'll tap "Approve" to make them stop, or call pretending to be IT support asking you to approve.

Passkeys: goodbye passwords

A **passkey** lets you sign in with your fingerprint, face, or phone PIN instead of a password. It's stored securely on your device and only works on the real website, so **it can't be stolen by a fake website**. Google, Apple, Microsoft, Amazon, PayPal, WhatsApp and many banks now support passkeys. When a service offers "Create a passkey", say yes.

Recovery: make sure you can get back in

- [ ] Add a recovery phone number and recovery email to your main email account — and keep them up to date.
- [ ] Print or write down backup codes for 2-step verification and store them safely at home.
- [ ] Set up "Legacy Contact" or "Inactive Account Manager" features so a trusted person can access your accounts if something happens to you.
- [ ] Check if your email has appeared in known data breaches at **haveibeenpwned.com**, and change any affected passwords.
- [ ] Use invented answers for security questions (e.g. "first pet: Purple Telescope") and store them in your password manager.

KIDS' CORNER

Your password is like a toothbrush: **don't share it, and get a good one!** Not even with your best friend — friendships change. Make a silly phrase with four random words, like "jelly-rocket-sock-tiger". Your parents can help you save it.

Chapter summary: **Unique passphrases + a password manager + 2-step verification.**
Start with your email account today. Choose passkeys whenever you can.



CHAPTER 10 · PART 3

Safe Devices, Safe Home Network

Phones, computers, tablets, smart TVs and Wi-Fi routers are the doors and windows of your digital home. A few simple settings keep them locked.

IN THIS CHAPTER

Updates · Screen locks · Safe apps · Fake virus pop-ups · Backups · Home Wi-Fi · Public Wi-Fi · Using AI assistants safely

The big five for every device

Habit	Why and how
1. Turn on automatic updates	Updates fix security holes that criminals actively use. Turn on automatic updates for your phone, computer, apps and browser. Restart when asked. Replace devices that no longer get security updates.
2. Lock your screen	Use a 6-digit PIN or longer, plus fingerprint or face unlock. Avoid 123456, 000000, or birthdays.
3. Install apps only from official stores	Apple App Store, Google Play, Microsoft Store, or the developer's official website. Never install apps from links in messages or calls.
4. Back up	Turn on iCloud, Google or OneDrive backup, and/or copy important photos and files to an external drive. Backups protect you from ransomware, theft and broken devices.
5. Turn on "Find My"	"Find My" (Apple) or "Find My Device" (Android) lets you locate, lock or erase a lost phone. On iPhone, also consider *Stolen Device Protection*.

Fake virus warnings and pop-ups

A loud, flashing message suddenly fills your screen: "WARNING! Your computer is infected! Call Microsoft Support now on…" — sometimes with a robotic voice. **It's fake.** Real virus warnings never include a phone number to call.

1. Don't call the number. Don't click anything in the message.
2. Close the browser. If it won't close: on Windows press **Ctrl + Shift + Esc** and end the browser; on a Mac press **Cmd + Option + Esc** and Force Quit. Or simply restart the computer.
3. When you reopen the browser, don't restore the previous pages.

Antivirus and security tools

Windows has **Microsoft Defender** built in, and Macs, iPhones and Android phones have built-in protections. Keep them switched on. If you buy extra security software, buy it directly from a reputable company — **never** from a pop-up or caller. Also consider turning on your browser's enhanced protection (e.g. Chrome's "Enhanced protection" in Safe Browsing).

Your home Wi-Fi router

- [ ] Change the router's admin password from the default (it's often on a sticker).
- [ ] Use WPA3 or WPA2 encryption with a long Wi-Fi password.
- [ ] Turn on automatic firmware updates if available. Replace very old routers your provider no longer supports.
- [ ] Set up a separate **guest network** for visitors and smart devices (TVs, doorbells, speakers, cameras).
- [ ] Change default passwords on smart cameras and baby monitors; turn on their 2-step verification.

Public Wi-Fi and travel

- Public Wi-Fi in cafés, airports and hotels is fine for browsing secure (https) websites, but beware of fake networks with names like "Free Airport WiFi".
- For banking on the go, use your phone's mobile data instead.
- Avoid public USB charging points; use your own plug or a charge-only cable.
- Never leave devices unlocked and unattended.

Using AI assistants safely

AI chatbots and assistants are useful — even for checking whether a message looks like a scam. Use them wisely:

DO

- Use the official app or website of a well-known AI service.
- Paste a suspicious message (with your personal details removed) and ask "Does this look like a scam?" — as a second opinion, not the final word.
- Double-check important facts, especially about money, health or law.

DON'T

- Type passwords, bank details, ID numbers or medical records into chatbots.
- Download "AI" apps or browser extensions from ads or unknown sites — many are malware.
- Trust an AI "financial advisor" or "trading bot" promising profits.

Getting rid of old devices

Before selling, gifting or recycling a phone, tablet or computer: back it up, sign out of all accounts (including Apple ID / Google account), turn off "Find My", and do a full **factory reset**.

KIDS' CORNER

Only download games and apps from the official app store — and ask first. If a website says your tablet has a virus or you've won a prize, **don't click anything**, just close it and tell a grown-up. And when the tablet says "update available", that's a good thing!

Chapter summary: **Update, lock, back up.** Install apps only from official stores.
A pop-up with a phone number is **always** a scam.



CHAPTER 11 · PART 4

For Kids & Teens

Young people are online more than anyone — and scammers know it. This chapter has a section to read with younger children, a section for teens, and a guide for parents.

IN THIS CHAPTER

The Internet Superhero rules (ages 6–11) · Gaming scams · Teens: real-world threats · Parents: setting up safely and keeping talking

Part A · For younger kids (ages 6–11): The Internet Superhero Rules

Hi! The internet is full of fun games, videos and friends. But some people online use tricks to fool kids. Superheroes know the tricks — and now you will too!

RULE 1 – KEEP YOUR SECRETS SECRET

Never tell anyone online your **full name, address, school, phone number, or passwords**. Not even if they say they're your friend, a game helper, or a famous YouTuber.

RULE 2 – "FREE" STUFF IS USUALLY A TRICK

Free coins, free skins, free Robux, free V-Bucks, free gift cards… If a website or message offers you free stuff for your password, **it's a trap**. Real games never ask for your password.

RULE 3 – STRANGERS ONLINE ARE STILL STRANGERS

Someone might say they are 10 years old, but they could be a grown-up. **Don't chat privately with people you don't know in real life**, and never send them photos.

RULE 4 – ASK BEFORE YOU CLICK, DOWNLOAD OR BUY

Links, pop-ups, apps and in-game purchases — **ask a grown-up first**. That's what superheroes do.

RULE 5 – KNOW THE FAMILY SECRET WORD

Computers can copy voices now. If someone calls or messages and says they're Mum, Dad, Grandma or a family friend asking you to do something strange, **ask for the secret word**. If they don't know it — hang up and tell a grown-up.

RULE 6 – UH-OH FEELINGS MEAN "TELL SOMEONE"

If something online makes you feel scared, sad, confused or uncomfortable — or someone tells you to keep a secret from your parents — **tell a grown-up you trust**. You will NOT be in trouble. Good secrets are surprises like birthday presents. Bad secrets make you feel worried.

Quick quiz for kids

1. A player in your game says: "Give me your password and I'll give you 10,000 free coins!" What do you do? — Say no, don't share it, and tell a grown-up. It's a trick to steal your account.

2. A video says you can win a new phone if you click a link. — Don't click! Close it and tell a grown-up.
3. Someone you don't know wants to video chat and says "Don't tell your parents." — That's a bad secret. Leave the chat and tell a grown-up right away.
4. Grandma calls but sounds a bit strange and asks you to read her the code from Mum's phone. — Ask for the secret word. Never share codes. Get a grown-up.

Part B · For teens (12–18)

You probably know more about apps than your parents. But criminals target teens specifically, and the scams aimed at you are some of the nastiest. Here's what's actually out there:

Threat	What it looks like	Your move
Sextortion	A flirty profile sends a photo, asks for one back — then threatens to send it to your followers unless you pay. Or uses AI to fake a nude from your normal pics.	Don't pay. Stop replying. Screenshot. Report. Tell an adult. Use Take It Down. *(Chapter 7)*
Account theft	"Vote for me", "Is this you?", fake giveaways, fake brand deals, "verify your account" DMs.	Never share codes. Turn on 2-step verification. Use a unique password.
Money mule recruiting	"Easy money — just let me use your bank account."	It's money laundering. It can wreck your future. Say no.
Fake jobs & side hustles	"Earn $300/day liking TikToks", "become a brand ambassador — pay for the starter kit".	Real jobs don't ask you to pay. Walk away.
Marketplace / ticket scams	Concert tickets, sneakers, consoles, game accounts for cheap.	Official sellers and protected payments only.
Gaming scams	Skin trading tricks, fake "middlemen", phishing login pages for Steam, Discord, Epic, Roblox.	Trade only inside the official platform. Check URLs. Never log in via links.
Crypto & "finfluencers"	"Get rich" coins, trading courses, pump-and-dump groups, AI trading bots.	If they're promising profits, they're profiting from you.
Deepfake bullying	Fake images or videos of classmates.	Don't share, don't make them. Report. It's harmful and often illegal.

TEEN SECURITY SETUP – 10 MINUTES

- [ ] Private accounts; limit DMs to people you follow.
- [ ] 2-step verification on Instagram, TikTok, Snapchat, Discord, gaming accounts and email.
- [ ] Unique passwords (use a password manager).
- [ ] Location sharing (e.g. Snap Map) set to friends you actually know — or off.
- [ ] Your contact details hidden from your profile.

A message to teens: if you ever get into a mess online — you clicked, paid, sent a photo, got threatened — the worst thing you can do is handle it alone. The criminals are counting on your embarrassment. Adults have made the same mistakes. Telling someone is how this ends.

Part C · For parents and carers

Set up devices safely

- Use built-in family tools: **Apple Screen Time / Family Sharing**, **Google Family Link**, **Microsoft Family Safety**, and console parental controls (Xbox, PlayStation, Nintendo).
- Turn on "**Ask to Buy**" or purchase approval, and don't store your card on a child's device or game account.
- Check age ratings for apps and games and use each app's teen or child account settings.
- For young children, keep devices in shared spaces and out of bedrooms at night.

Keep talking – it matters more than any app

- Ask about their online world with curiosity, not suspicion: "What's the best thing in that game? Has anyone ever been weird to you?"
- Promise — and keep the promise — that **telling you will never lead to automatic punishment** or losing their device. Fear of losing their phone stops kids telling parents.
- Share your own near-misses. It shows that anyone can be targeted.
- Practise together: use the quiz on page 66 and set up your family code word.
- Model good behaviour: ask your children before posting photos of them.

WARNING SIGNS A CHILD MAY BE IN TROUBLE ONLINE

Sudden secrecy about devices, switching screens when you come in, withdrawal, anxiety after being online, new gifts or money from unknown sources, new contacts they won't discuss, or sudden requests for money or gift cards. Stay calm, stay close, and ask gently.

Chapter summary: For kids – **STOP, THINK, ASK**. For teens – **never handle it alone**.
For parents – **keep talking, and never punish the telling**.



CHAPTER 12 · PART 4

For Grandparents & Those Who Care for Them

Older adults are targeted because they often have savings, are polite on the phone, and may be less familiar with new technology. But experience is a superpower: you've spotted con artists before. Here's how to spot the new ones.

IN THIS CHAPTER

The scams aimed at older adults · Ten golden rules · Setting up your phone for peace of mind · Banking safety · How families can help without taking over

The scams most aimed at older adults

Scam	What happens
Grandparent / family emergency	A cloned voice of a grandchild in trouble. A "lawyer" or "police officer" asks for cash, often collected by a courier. (Chapter 5)
Bank "safe account"	A fake fraud team convinces you to move savings to protect them. (Chapter 5)
Fake police / courier	"We've arrested someone with your card. A courier will collect your card and PIN as evidence."
Tech support	A pop-up or call about a virus; they take control of your computer. (Chapter 10)
Government / pension / health insurance	Calls about pension "updates", tax, Medicare or health cards asking for ID numbers or payments.
Romance & companionship	Particularly targets widowed or lonely people, building trust for months. (Chapter 7)
Investment & gold	Persuaded to cash in pensions or buy gold to hand over "for safekeeping".
Doorstep & home repair	Overpriced or unnecessary roof, driveway or energy work, often after "noticing a problem".
Prize & lottery	"You've won — pay the taxes first."

Ten golden rules

1. **I never give my PIN, passwords or the codes sent to my phone to anyone.** Not to my bank, not to the police.
2. **I never move money to a "safe account".** There is no such thing.
3. **I never hand my card, cash or gold to a courier** or anyone who comes to the door.
4. **I never pay with gift cards, crypto or cash transfers** to someone who contacted me.
5. **I hang up and call back** on a number I find myself — using a different phone or after waiting five minutes.
6. **I ask for the family code word** when "family" calls in an emergency.
7. **I never let anyone control my computer** if they contacted me first.
8. **I don't keep secrets about money.** If anyone says "don't tell your family or bank", I tell them immediately.
9. **I can always say "no", "I'll think about it", or simply hang up.** Politeness is not owed to strangers.
10. **I talk to my trusted person before any large or unusual payment.**

Set up your phone and accounts for peace of mind

- [ ] Save important numbers — family, doctor, bank fraud line from your card — with clear names, so unknown callers stand out.
- [ ] Turn on spam call blocking and "Silence unknown callers" if it suits you. Ask your phone company about free call-blocking.
- [ ] Let unknown numbers go to voicemail. Real callers will leave a message.
- [ ] Ask your bank about extra protections: lower daily transfer limits, a "trusted contact" who can be alerted to unusual activity, delays on large new payments, and card-only alerts by text.
- [ ] Register with your country's "do not call" list (for example, the National Do Not Call Registry in the US, or the Telephone Preference Service in the UK).
- [ ] Put a "No cold callers" sign on your front door.
- [ ] Ask a family member to help set up automatic updates, a screen lock and 2-step verification (Chapters 9–10).

REAL-LIFE STORY

Henrik, 81, got a call from "the bank's security department". The caller knew his name, address and the last four digits of his card. "Your account is being targeted by criminals inside the bank — we need to move your savings to a protected account tonight. Don't tell the branch staff; they may be involved." Henrik had read the golden rules. He said, "I'll call you back," hung up, and called his daughter, who called the bank with him using the number on his card. His savings were untouched. The bank confirmed: they never call to ask customers to move money.

For families and carers: helping without taking over

- **Respect independence.** The goal is confidence, not control. Lead with "Can I show you something I learned?" rather than "You'll get scammed."
- **Practise.** Role-play a scam call together. It's far easier to hang up in real life once you've practised saying the words.
- **Be the "trusted person".** Agree that they'll call you before any unusual payment — and that you'll answer or call back quickly, and never make them feel foolish.
- **Simplify technology.** Fewer apps, larger text, saved contacts, automatic updates, and a password manager or safe paper password book.
- **Look for warning signs:** new "friends" they're secretive about, unusual withdrawals, gift-card purchases, remote-access apps on their computer, couriers visiting, or sudden anxiety about money.
- **Plan ahead.** Discuss powers of attorney and bank trusted-contact options while everything is fine.

IF IT HAPPENS

If you've been scammed, please tell someone and call your bank straight away. Shame is the scammer's last weapon — don't let them keep it. Banks, police and support services hear these stories every day, from people of every age and background. Chapter 13 tells you exactly what to do.

Chapter summary: **No PINs, no codes, no couriers, no "safe accounts", no secrets.**
Hang up, call back, and talk to your trusted person.



CHAPTER 13 · PART 5

If It Happens to You: The Recovery Plan

If you've clicked, paid, or shared something you shouldn't have — take a breath. You are not stupid, and you are not alone. What you do in the next hour matters most. Follow these steps.

IN THIS CHAPTER

The first hour · Step-by-step by situation · Hacked accounts · Identity theft · Reporting · Looking after yourself

The first hour: four steps

1

Stop contact

Hang up, stop replying, don't send anything more — even if they threaten or promise refunds.

2

Call your bank

Use the number on your card or in your banking app. Say "I think I've been scammed." Ask them to stop or recall payments.

3

Secure accounts

Change passwords starting with your email. Turn on 2-step verification. Sign out of other devices.

4

Report & tell

Report to police / fraud authority. Tell a trusted person. Save all evidence.

What to do – by situation

If you…	Do this now
Paid by card	Call your card provider immediately. Block the card. Ask for a **chargeback** / dispute.
Made a bank transfer	Call your bank immediately — minutes count. Ask them to try to recall the payment. In some countries, banks must reimburse many victims of authorised push payment fraud; ask about it.
Paid with gift cards	Contact the gift-card company immediately (number on the card or their website) with the card numbers and receipts. Some can freeze unused balance.
Sent cryptocurrency	Report to the exchange you used and to the police. Record wallet addresses and transaction IDs. **Beware of "recovery" services** — they are usually scams.
Shared a password	Change it immediately on the real site, plus anywhere you reused it. Turn on 2-step verification.
Shared a verification code	Assume the account is being taken over. Change the password, sign out all sessions, check recovery email/phone haven't been changed, and contact the service.
Gave remote access to your computer	Disconnect from the internet (turn off Wi-Fi, unplug cable). Call your bank. From a different, safe device, change important passwords. Have the computer checked or reset by a trusted professional before using online banking again.

Gave ID details (passport, ID number, SSN, etc.)	Report identity theft to the relevant authority. Consider a **credit freeze** with credit agencies where available. Watch your bank and credit reports.
Lost phone number to a "SIM swap" (phone suddenly has no signal)	Call your phone company from another phone immediately. Then call your bank.
Are being blackmailed	Don't pay. Stop replying. Save evidence. Report to police. Use Take It Down / StopNCII (Chapter 7).

Recovering a hacked account

1. Use the service's official recovery page (search for "[service name] hacked account recovery", typing the official site yourself).
2. Once back in: change the password, turn on 2-step verification, check recovery email and phone, remove unknown devices, and check settings like email forwarding rules (criminals add these to secretly copy your mail).
3. Warn your contacts that messages from your account may have been fake.
4. Check other accounts that use the same email or password.

Collect evidence

- ☐ Screenshots of messages, profiles, websites and ads (include usernames and web addresses).
- ☐ Phone numbers, email addresses, dates and times of calls.
- ☐ Bank statements, receipts, transaction IDs, wallet addresses, gift-card numbers.
- ☐ Write down what happened while it's fresh: who, what, when, how much.

Report it – every time

Reporting helps police find patterns, helps banks freeze criminal accounts, and protects others. Even small or "failed" scams are worth reporting. See page 69 for where to report in different countries.

Look after yourself

Being scammed can feel like a burglary of the mind: shock, anger, shame, sleeplessness, and fear. These feelings are normal. Please:

- **Talk to someone.** Family, friends, your doctor, or a victim support service.

- **Remember who's to blame:** the criminals — organised professionals who use psychology and technology to deceive.
- **Watch for a second wave:** scammers often target the same people again, including with "recovery" offers.
- **If you're having thoughts of harming yourself**, contact emergency services or a crisis line right away. You matter far more than any amount of money.

KIDS' CORNER

If you clicked something, shared a password, or someone online is scaring you — **tell a grown-up right now**. Grown-ups can fix most problems, especially if they know quickly. You won't be in trouble for telling the truth.

Chapter summary: **Stop contact. Call your bank. Secure accounts. Report and tell.**
Speed matters more than embarrassment.

Toolkit A · Our Family Safety Plan

Fill this in together. Keep it somewhere private at home — **not** on social media or in a shared online document. Review it once a year.

1. Our family code word

Code word / phrase (never posted, never said first):

Back-up question and answer:

2. Our "trusted person" rule

Before any unusual payment over _____, or any request involving gift cards, crypto, codes or secrecy, we call:

Trusted person 1 – name & number:

Trusted person 2 – name & number:

3. Important numbers (look these up yourself – e.g. on the back of your card)

Bank fraud line:

Credit card provider:

Mobile phone company:

Police (non-emergency) / national fraud reporting line:

Someone who's good with technology:

4. Our family promises

- [ ] Nobody gets told off for asking "Is this real?" or for admitting a mistake.
- [ ] We never share codes, PINs or passwords — with anyone.
- [ ] We always hang up and call back on a number we know.
- [ ] We use 2-step verification on email, banking and social media.
- [ ] We tell each other about scams we've seen, so everyone learns.

Signed by everyone:

Toolkit B · The 30-Minute Security Check-up

Do this once a year for each family member — or help a grandparent do theirs. Tick as you go.

Email (do this first!)

- [ ] Unique, long password or passkey
- [ ] 2-step verification turned on
- [ ] Recovery phone and email up to date
- [ ] No unknown forwarding rules or devices
- [ ] Checked haveibeenpwned.com

Banking & money

- [ ] Banking app from official store; passkey / 2SV on
- [ ] Transaction alerts switched on
- [ ] Sensible daily transfer limits set
- [ ] Bank fraud number saved in contacts
- [ ] Card not saved on children's devices

Phone

- [ ] Screen lock 6+ digits, plus face / fingerprint
- [ ] Automatic updates on
- [ ] Find My / Find My Device on
- [ ] Spam call and message filtering on
- [ ] SIM / account PIN set with phone company
- [ ] Chat apps (WhatsApp etc.) two-step PIN on

Computer

- [ ] Automatic updates on; old software removed
- [ ] Built-in security (e.g. Defender) on
- [ ] Browser up to date; unknown extensions removed
- [ ] No remote-access apps you didn't install yourself
- [ ] Backup working (and tested!)

Social media

- [ ] Accounts private; strangers can't message
- [ ] 2-step verification on
- [ ] Old public posts / videos reviewed
- [ ] Location sharing off or limited
- [ ] Connected apps reviewed

Home

- [ ] Router admin password changed; updates on
- [ ] Guest Wi-Fi for visitors and smart devices
- [ ] Smart cameras: default passwords changed
- [ ] Password manager or safe paper book in use
- [ ] Family code word agreed and practised
- [ ] Family Safety Plan filled in

Toolkit C · Scam or Safe? The Family Quiz

Read each situation aloud. Everyone decides: **Scam, Safe, or Check first?** Answers are on the next page — no peeking!

1. An email from your streaming service says your payment failed and gives a link to update your card. It uses your real name and has no spelling mistakes.
2. Your bank's real number appears on your phone. The caller says your account is under attack and you must move your savings to a new "safe account" today.
3. You get a text: "Hi Dad, I dropped my phone in the toilet 🙈 this is my new number. Can you help me pay a bill? I'll pay you back tomorrow."
4. Your grandson calls, crying, saying he's been arrested. He sounds exactly like himself. He begs you not to tell his parents.
5. You receive a text with a 6-digit code you didn't ask for. A minute later, a message from a friend's account says: "Sorry, I sent my code to you by mistake, can you send it back?"
6. While browsing, a flashing red screen says your computer is infected and you must call Microsoft on the number shown.
7. You log into your banking app yourself and see a new message from the bank in the app's inbox about a change to their terms.
8. A video ad shows a famous TV presenter explaining how she made millions with a new AI trading platform. Register today — only 50 places left.
9. A game player offers to give you a rare skin if you log in through their website to "confirm the trade".
10. Your boss sends an urgent email from what looks like their address: a new supplier must be paid today, keep it confidential, they're in a meeting and can't talk.
11. A woman you met on a dating app 3 months ago, who can never video-call properly, needs €2,000 for an emergency operation.
12. A parking meter has a QR code sticker that looks slightly crooked and placed on top of another sticker.
13. Your phone shows a sign-in approval request — "Is this you trying to sign in?" — but you're watching TV.
14. A buyer for the bike you're selling online sends a link so you can "receive the payment" by entering your card details.
15. An email says someone has hacked your webcam and recorded you, and demands $1,500 in Bitcoin. It even includes an old password of yours.

Quiz answers

1. **Scam (or check first).** Name and perfect spelling prove nothing. Open the app or type the website yourself.
2. **Scam.** Numbers can be spoofed, and there is no such thing as a "safe account". Hang up, call the number on your card.
3. **Scam until proven otherwise.** Call your child on their old number. Ask the code word.
4. **Check first — very likely a scam.** Ask for the family code word; hang up and call him and his parents. Voices can be cloned.
5. **Scam.** That code is the key to *your* account; your friend's account was probably hijacked. Never share codes.
6. **Scam.** Real warnings never show a phone number. Close the browser or restart.
7. **Safe.** You went to the bank yourself — that's the right way to check messages.
8. **Scam.** A deepfake ad. Celebrities don't sell secret platforms, and urgency is a red flag.
9. **Scam.** A phishing site to steal your account. Trade only inside the official game.
10. **Check first — very likely a scam.** Business email compromise. Verify by phone on a known number before any payment.
11. **Scam.** Someone you've never met in person asking for money is a romance scammer.
12. **Likely scam.** Use the official parking app or pay at the machine.
13. **Someone has your password.** Tap Deny, then change your password straight away.
14. **Scam.** You never need card details to *receive* money.
15. **Scam (a bluff).** The old password came from a data leak. Don't pay or reply; change that password everywhere you used it and turn on 2SV.

HOW DID YOU DO?

13–15: Scam-spotting expert — now teach someone else! **9–12:** Great instincts; re-read Chapter 2. **Under 9:** No problem — that's what this book is for. Try the quiz again next month.

Toolkit D · Cut-out Wallet Card & Fridge Poster

Cut along the dashed line, fold in the middle, and keep it in your wallet or next to the phone.

STOP – IS IT A SCAM?

- They contacted **me**
- It's **urgent**
- They want **money, gift cards, crypto**
- They want a **code, PIN or password**
- They want **remote access**
- They say **keep it secret**
- It's **too good to be true**

PAUSE

Pause – take a breath
Ask – what do they want?
Use another way – call back
Share – tell someone
Exit – hang up, block, report

Bank: _____
Trusted person: _____

Our Family Never...

— the fridge poster —

- ❌ ...shares codes, PINs or passwords
- ❌ ...moves money to a "safe account"
- ❌ ...pays with gift cards or crypto
- ❌ ...hands cards or cash to a courier
- ❌ ...gives a stranger remote access
- ❌ ...keeps money secrets
- ❌ ...logs in through a link in a message
- ❌ ...trusts a voice or face alone

- ✅ We hang up and call back
- ✅ We ask for the code word
- ✅ We talk before we pay
- ✅ We never get told off for asking

Toolkit E · Where to Get Help & Report Scams

In an emergency, or if a crime is happening right now (for example, a courier is on the way to collect money), call your emergency number: **112** (EU and many countries), **911** (US/Canada), **999** (UK), **000** (Australia). Always contact your **bank first** if money is involved. The services below were correct at the time of writing; always check you are on the official government site.

Where you live	Report and get help
United States	FTC: **ReportFraud.ftc.gov** · FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center: **ic3.gov** · Identity theft recovery plan: **IdentityTheft.gov** · DOJ National Elder Fraud Hotline: **1-833-FRAUD-11** (1-833-372-8311) · AARP Fraud Watch Helpline: **877-908-3360** · Forward scam texts to **7726**
United Kingdom	National fraud & cybercrime reporting (formerly Action Fraud): **0300 123 2040** (Police Scotland: **101**) · Call **159** to reach your bank safely · Forward scam texts to **7726** · Forward scam emails to **report@phishing.gov.uk**
Canada	Canadian Anti-Fraud Centre: **antifraudcentre.ca** · **1-888-495-8501** · Forward scam texts to **7726**
Australia	Scamwatch: **scamwatch.gov.au** · ReportCyber: **cyber.gov.au** · IDCARE (identity & cyber support): **1800 595 160**
European Union	Report to your national police (112 in emergencies) and your national cybersecurity centre / CERT. Cross-border shopping problems: **European Consumer Centres Network (ECC-Net)**. Advice: **europol.europa.eu** (crime prevention pages).
Anywhere	Check if your email was in a data breach: **haveibeenpwned.com** · Remove intimate images (under 18): **takeitdown.ncmec.org** · Adults: **StopNCII.org** · Report scam ads and profiles directly on the platform (Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, YouTube, etc.)

Write in your local numbers

Emergency:

Police non-emergency / fraud reporting:

National cybersecurity centre / consumer protection:

Victim support service:

Toolkit F · Glossary: Cyber Words Made Simple

2-step verification (2SV / 2FA / MFA): a second check when you log in, like a code or phone prompt, so a password alone isn't enough.

AI (artificial intelligence): computer programs that can write, talk, create images and make decisions in ways that seem human.

Attachment: a file sent with an email or message.

Authenticator app: a phone app that makes login codes that change every 30 seconds.

Backup: a copy of your files kept somewhere else, in case something goes wrong.

Business email compromise (BEC): a scam where criminals pose as a boss or supplier to get a business to pay them.

Chargeback: asking your card provider to reverse a card payment.

Credential stuffing: trying leaked usernames and passwords on many websites.

Credit freeze: blocking new credit being opened in your name.

Data breach: when a company's information is stolen or leaked.

Deepfake: a fake video, image or audio of a real person made with AI.

Domain: the main part of a web address, like *example.com*.

Encryption: scrambling information so only the right person can read it.

Firewall: a security barrier that blocks unwanted network traffic.

Gift-card scam: being told to pay with gift cards — always a scam.

Hacker: someone who breaks into computers or accounts.

Identity theft: using your personal details to pretend to be you.

Malware: harmful software, such as viruses, spyware and ransomware.

Money mule: someone who moves stolen money through their bank account — a crime.

Passkey: a password replacement using your fingerprint, face or PIN; can't be phished.

Passphrase: a long password made of several random words.

Password manager: a secure app that creates and remembers your passwords.

Phishing: fake messages that try to trick you into clicking, sharing or paying.

Pig butchering: a long friendship or romance con leading to a fake investment.

QR code: a square barcode that opens a link. Quishing = QR code phishing.

Ransomware: malware that locks your files and demands payment.

Remote access: controlling a computer from somewhere else over the internet.

Romance scam: a fake relationship used to get money.

Safe account scam: being told to move your money to "protect" it — it goes to criminals.

Sextortion: blackmail using real or fake intimate images.

SIM swap: criminals moving your phone number to their SIM card to get your codes.

Smishing: phishing by text message (SMS).

Social engineering: manipulating people into giving away information or money.

Spear-phishing: phishing aimed at a specific person using personal details.

Spoofing: faking a phone number, email address or website to look genuine.

Update / patch: a software fix, often for security holes.

URL: a web address.

Vishing: phishing by voice — phone calls.

Voice cloning: using AI to copy someone's voice.

VPN: a service that encrypts your internet connection.

Technology will keep changing. The scammer's skeleton never does:
Contact → Story → Pressure → Payment.
Meet it every time with **PAUSE** – and with each other.

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Share it freely with family, friends, schools and community groups.